

The Last Letter

By Noah Williams

A thoughtful story about friendship, distance, and home

When Daniel found the letter, it was almost midnight, and the rain outside had been falling steadily for more than an hour. He had spent most of the evening sorting through old boxes in the small room that had once belonged to his mother, although he could not have explained why he had suddenly decided to do it after avoiding the room for nearly three years.

The house had been unusually quiet since his mother's death. Even after all that time, Daniel still sometimes expected to hear her moving dishes around in the kitchen or calling his name from downstairs, asking whether he had remembered to eat. He had learned to live with the silence, but that night the rain seemed to make the house feel even emptier, as though every drop against the window was reminding him of everything that had changed.

He was looking through a cardboard box filled with old photographs, school certificates, birthday cards, and documents that no longer seemed important when he noticed a thin brown envelope at the bottom. His name was written across the front in handwriting he recognized immediately.

Daniel.

He stared at it for several seconds before picking it up.

There was no address and no stamp, which meant that it had never been posted. On the back of the envelope, in his mother's handwriting, were four simple words: **Give this to him.**

Daniel turned the envelope over again, wondering who "him" was.

Then he saw the date.

The letter had been written almost ten years earlier.

He sat down on the wooden floor and carefully opened it.

Dear Daniel,

If you are reading this, then I am probably no longer here to explain why I kept this letter for so long. I hope you will forgive me for that.

There is something I should have told you years ago. You had a friend named Samuel who came to this house often when you were younger. I know you remember him. After you left for university, he came here several times looking for you. At first, I told him you were busy, but eventually I told him the truth.

He was struggling, Daniel. His family was going through a difficult time, and he needed someone he trusted. He asked me to give you a letter, but you had already left for another city and were not answering his messages.

I kept his letter because I thought you would return soon.

You never did.

I don't know whether you and Samuel ever found your way back to each other, but I always believed that some friendships deserve another chance.

If you still have the chance to find him, please do.

Your mother.

Daniel read the letter twice, and then a third time, as the memories slowly returned.

Samuel.

For years, he had almost managed to forget that name.

They had met when they were thirteen, on a dusty football field behind their secondary school. Daniel had been standing alone after losing his bicycle key when Samuel walked over and asked why he looked so worried. Within an hour, Samuel had helped him search the entire field, and by the end of the afternoon they had discovered that the key had been inside Daniel's schoolbag all along.

That should have been an ordinary childhood memory, but somehow it had become the beginning of a friendship that lasted through most of their teenage years.

They studied together, played football together, argued about music, shared food when one of them had no money, and spent long evenings talking about the lives they imagined they would have one day. Samuel wanted to become an engineer because he loved taking things apart and putting them back together, while Daniel dreamed of leaving their small town and building a career somewhere far away.

Whenever Daniel talked about the future, Samuel would laugh and tell him, "When you become successful, don't start pretending you don't know me."

Daniel would always answer that he could never forget him.

But people sometimes make promises when they are young without understanding how difficult it can be to keep them.

After secondary school, Daniel received an opportunity to study in another city. It was everything he had wanted, and he left without hesitation. During the first few months, he and Samuel stayed in contact almost every day. They talked on the phone, sent messages, and promised to visit each other whenever they had enough money.

Then Daniel became busy.

His classes became harder, and he took a part-time job to support himself. He began spending more time with new friends, people who knew nothing about the town he had come from or the boy who had once helped him find a bicycle key on a football field.

Samuel continued calling, but Daniel began returning his calls less often.

Sometimes he saw a message and told himself he would answer later. Later became tomorrow, tomorrow became next week, and eventually the messages stopped.

Daniel had always believed that friendships ended because people had a serious argument or because someone did something unforgivable.

He had never considered that a friendship could simply disappear because one person kept postponing the effort required to maintain it.

Now, sitting on his mother's floor with the old letter in his hands, he wondered how different his life might have been if he had answered one of those calls.

The following morning, Daniel searched through his old phone contacts, but Samuel's number was no longer there. He checked his email, searched through social media, and even looked through an old notebook where he had written down the phone numbers of people he knew at university.

Nothing.

He nearly gave up until he remembered something Samuel had once told him.

"My uncle has a repair shop near the old market," Samuel had said. "If you ever lose me, start there."

Daniel had laughed at the time because he could not imagine ever losing his best friend.

By ten o'clock that morning, he was standing in front of a small electronics repair shop near the market.

The place looked older than he remembered, although Daniel was not sure whether it had actually changed or whether his memory had simply made everything seem larger when he was younger. A middle-aged man was sitting behind the counter, repairing a radio, and Daniel

hesitated before asking, "Excuse me, does Samuel Mensah still come here?"

The man looked up.

For a moment, his face showed no recognition. Then his eyes narrowed as he studied Daniel carefully.

"Daniel?"

Daniel's heart jumped.

"Yes."

The man placed the radio on the counter and stood up slowly. "I haven't seen you in years."

Daniel smiled awkwardly. "You remember me?"

"I remember the two of you coming here when you were boys. Samuel talked about you all the time."

Daniel lowered his eyes.

The man's expression changed when he noticed the sadness on Daniel's face. "Samuel doesn't live here anymore. He moved to another city about six years ago."

"Do you have his number?"

The man shook his head. "I don't, but I know where he works."

He wrote an address on a small piece of paper and handed it to Daniel.

"He repairs industrial machines now. He was always good with his hands."

Daniel looked at the address, then folded the paper carefully and placed it in his pocket.

"Thank you."

As he turned to leave, the man called after him.

"Daniel."

He stopped.

"If you're going to see him, don't waste the opportunity."

Daniel looked back.

The man smiled sadly. "Some people wait a long time to hear an apology."

The journey to Samuel's city took almost four hours. Daniel spent most of it looking through the window, watching familiar landscapes disappear behind him and wondering what he would say when they finally met.

He imagined Samuel being angry.

He imagined him refusing to speak.

He imagined the two of them laughing about their childhood as though nothing had happened.

What Daniel could not imagine was how he would explain ten years of silence.

When he arrived at the address, he found a large workshop filled with machines, tools, metal parts, and the constant sound of people working. A young woman at the reception desk asked whom he wanted to see, and when Daniel gave Samuel's name, she pointed toward a man standing beside a large machine at the far end of the building.

Daniel recognized him immediately.

Samuel was older, of course. His hair was shorter, his face was thinner, and there were lines around his eyes that Daniel did not remember, but there was something about the way he stood, the slight movement of his shoulders as he concentrated on his work, that made Daniel feel as though he were looking at the same boy who had once searched an entire football field for a missing bicycle key.

Samuel looked up.

Their eyes met.

Neither man moved.

Daniel suddenly became aware of how foolish he felt. He had spent hours imagining this moment, but now that it had arrived, every prepared sentence had disappeared from his mind.

Samuel slowly removed his gloves.

"Daniel?"

Daniel nodded.

"I've been looking for you."

Samuel's expression remained difficult to read. "For how long?"

Daniel swallowed. "Since yesterday."

A quiet smile appeared on Samuel's face, but it was not a happy one.

"That sounds about right."

The words hurt more than Daniel expected.

They walked outside and sat beneath a large tree behind the workshop. For several minutes, neither of them spoke. The silence between them was uncomfortable, but Daniel knew he had no right to escape from it.

Finally, he told Samuel about the letter.

When he finished, Samuel looked down at his hands.

"I wondered what happened to that letter," he said.

"You knew about it?"

"I wrote it."

Daniel looked at him. "My mother said you came looking for me."

"I did."

"Why didn't you try harder to find me?"

Samuel gave a quiet laugh. "I did try. But after a while, I started feeling like I was the only one trying."

Daniel had no answer.

Samuel continued, speaking slowly as though he had carried the words for many years and wanted to make sure he chose them carefully. "My mother was sick back then. We had a lot of problems at home, and I didn't know what I was going to do. I didn't need money from you, Daniel. I just wanted my friend. I thought if I could talk to you, maybe things wouldn't feel so heavy."

Daniel looked away.

"I should have answered."

"Yes."

"I should have called you back."

"Yes."

"I don't have a good excuse."

Samuel nodded. "I know."

The honesty of the answer left Daniel silent.

After a while, Samuel smiled faintly. "You know what hurt the most?"

Daniel shook his head.

"I kept telling myself you were busy. Then I told myself you would call when things became easier. Eventually, I started wondering whether our friendship had only mattered to me."

Daniel felt his throat tighten.

"It mattered to me," he said.

Samuel looked at him.

"It mattered to me a lot. I was just so focused on building the life I thought I needed that I didn't notice what I was losing."

For the first time, Samuel's expression softened.

"That sounds like you."

Daniel laughed quietly. "I suppose it does."

They spent the next few hours talking about everything they had missed. Samuel told Daniel about his mother's illness, the years he had spent learning mechanical repair, and the small business he had eventually started with two other technicians. Daniel told him about his career, the cities he had lived in, the relationships that had failed, and the strange loneliness that could exist even when a person appeared successful from the outside.

They discovered that they had both changed, but perhaps not as much as they had believed.

Samuel still laughed loudly when he found something funny. Daniel still became serious whenever he talked about his plans for the future. They still disagreed about football, and Samuel still insisted that Daniel had terrible taste in music.

By the time the sun began to set, the years between them seemed less like a wall and more like a long road they had finally decided to walk back together.

Before Daniel left, Samuel asked him a question.

"Why did you really come?"

Daniel thought about it.

"I found my mother's letter."

"That's not what I mean."

Daniel looked at his old friend and understood.

He could have read the letter and felt guilty. He could have told himself that the past was too far away to repair. He could have closed the envelope, placed it back in the box, and continued with his life.

Instead, he had driven four hours because some part of him knew that an apology was not enough if it remained unspoken.

"I came because I didn't want to lose another ten years," he said.

Samuel nodded slowly.

"Good answer."

They shook hands before Daniel left, but the handshake lasted only a second before Samuel pulled him into a hug.

Daniel closed his eyes.

For a moment, he was thirteen again, standing on a dusty football field beside the boy who had helped him search for something he had never actually lost.

On the journey home, Daniel thought about his mother's letter.

She had written it years before, probably without knowing whether he would ever find Samuel again. Perhaps she had understood something that Daniel had been too young and too busy to understand himself: distance does not always destroy relationships, but silence often does.

When Daniel arrived home that night, he returned to the small room and placed the letter carefully inside a drawer beside his bed. He did not put it back into the old box.

Then he took out his phone.

Samuel had already sent him a message.

Don't disappear again.

Daniel smiled.

He typed a reply, deleted it, and typed another.

I won't.

This time, he sent it immediately.

Outside, the rain had stopped, and the streets were quiet beneath the pale light of the moon. Daniel stood by the window for a while, thinking about all the people who had once been important to him and wondering how many friendships had quietly disappeared simply because he had assumed there would always be more time.

He knew now that there was no guarantee of that.

Sometimes a person leaves because life takes them somewhere else.
Sometimes people grow apart because their dreams change.
Sometimes distance becomes too great, and there is nothing either person can do about it.

But sometimes, a friendship is not truly lost.

Sometimes it is simply waiting for someone to pick up the last letter, open it, and finally decide to answer.

The End.

Glossary

Steadily: happening continuously without stopping or changing much.

Hesitate: to pause because you are unsure what to do.

Recognition: the feeling of knowing someone or something because you have seen it before.

Opportunity: a good chance to do something.

Apology: words used to say that you are sorry for something.

Loneliness: the feeling of being alone or missing close relationships.

Repair: to fix something that is broken or damaged.

Guarantee: a promise or assurance that something will happen.